

FUEL SHIFT People queue at a petrol pump dispensing E20 fuel, Kolkata, Jul. 7

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

ment's record of delivery. In January, 24 per cent rated India's roads and infrastructure 'excellent'. That has fallen six points to 18 per cent. The combined 'excellent' and 'good' rating has dropped from 51 per cent to 45.6 per cent, the lowest in the past four surveys, while 'poor' and 'very poor' together have risen from 21.2 per cent to 25.2 per cent, the highest of the four readings. This matters because infrastructure has been one of the Modi government's strongest and most visible claims to performance.

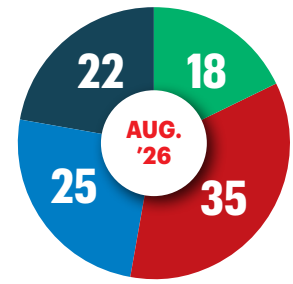
The ethanol question tells a similar story about the limits of top-down policymaking. Only 18 per cent want the current higher-blending policy continued without change, 35 per cent want safeguards and clearer guidance for potentially incompatible vehicles, while another 25 per cent want incompatible vehicles exempted altogether. In effect, 60 per cent want some change in policy.

46 PER CENT rate the quality of public transport as 'good' or 'excellent', same as in the previous survey

QUIET SHIFTS

There are other revealing trends. On communal harmony, only 34 per cent now say it has improved under the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government, down from 39.6 per cent in January and matching the lowest level recorded since 2021. But the share saying the situation has 'deteriorated' has also fallen, from 32.2 per cent to 29.5 per cent. Where have respondents moved? Towards 'remained the same', which has climbed to 22.7 per cent, and those who are uncertain, whose figure has nearly doubled to 13.8 per cent. Rather than straightforward communal polarisa-

Q. What should the Union government do about mandatory higher ethanol blending in petrol, given concerns about compatibility with some vehicles?



Continue the current policy without change
Continue, but issue safeguards and clear guidance for potentially incompatible vehicles
Exempt vehicles that are not fully compatible with higher ethanol blends
Rest, DK/ CS

60% of respondents want exemptions or safeguards rather than continuing the ethanol blending policy as it is